

CANADA 2014

1.	Overview of the tax-benefit system	2
2.	Unemployment insurance.....	3
3.	Unemployment assistance.....	9
4.	Social assistance.....	10
5.	Housing benefits for rented accommodation	13
6.	Family benefits.....	14
7.	Childcare for pre-school children.....	18
8.	Employment-conditional benefits	20
9.	Lone-parent benefits	22
10.	Tax system	24
11.	Part-time work.....	29
12.	Policy developments	30

Introduction

Tax-benefit policy “country chapters” are made available as part of the OECD series Benefits and Wages. They provide detailed descriptions of tax and benefit rules in a consistent format across countries and summarize recent policy changes.

Country chapters for other countries and years are available on the Internet at www.oecd.org/els/social/workincentives.

1. Overview of the tax-benefit system

The system of benefits and incentives in Canada comprises a number of programs, including benefit programs and tax assistance. Some are the responsibility of the federal (national) government, while others are administered by provincial and territorial governments. These programs include unemployment benefits, social assistance (or welfare), and a number of federal and provincial benefits and credits delivered through the personal income tax system (related to children, shelter, supplements for working income, etc). Due to the breadth and variety of programs at the provincial and territorial level, the Province of Ontario has been chosen where examples of provincial/territorial programs are required (Ontario has also been used as an example in previous editions of this report).

With respect to benefits, Employment Insurance (as it is called in Canada) provides temporary income support to Canadians workers while they are temporarily unemployed and looking for work or upgrading their skills, while they are pregnant or caring for a newborn or adopted child, while they are sick, or for workers who need to take a short-term absence from work in order to provide care or support to a gravely ill family member facing a significant risk of death within six months, or for parents unable to work while providing care or support to a child whose life is at risk as a result of an illness or injury. Benefits are earnings-related and are subject to a maximum amount (see section 2). Social assistance provides financial assistance to cover the cost of basic living requirements, and in-kind goods and services, for an individual or family when all other financial resources have been exhausted (see section 4 for more information). The Canada Child Tax Benefit, which includes the National Child Benefit Supplement, is a federal income-tested benefit for families with children (see section 6). Provinces and territories also provide a range of benefits and services for families with children. Both the federal government and the provinces and territories are involved in the provision of child care assistance through direct benefits, the personal income tax system and subsidies.

With respect to taxation, the federal personal income tax system in Canada is progressive, meaning that tax rates rise as taxable income rises. It also includes many deductions, exemptions, and tax credits (both refundable, i.e., non-wastable, and non-refundable i.e., wastable) which serve to reduce taxes payable. Provinces and territories also set their own tax on personal income. See section 10 for further details.

1.1. Average Worker wage (AW)

The 2014 AW earnings level is CAD 49 481¹

¹ AW refers to the Average Wage estimated by the Centre for Tax Policy and Administration (www.oecd.org/ctp). For more information, see *Taxing Wages 2010-2011*, OECD, 2012, part 5, sections 2 and 3.

2. Unemployment insurance

2.1 Conditions for receipt

All persons in paid employment and fishers who contribute to the Employment Insurance (EI) program by paying premiums are potentially eligible to receive EI regular and special benefits.

Self-employed Canadians (other than fishers) are able to opt in to the EI program on a voluntary basis to be eligible for EI special benefits (maternity, parental, sickness, compassionate care and parents of critically ill children benefits) only.

2.1.1 Employment conditions

As shown in the table below, entrance requirements for EI regular benefits vary with the local monthly EI unemployment rate. A minimum of 420 hours of work in their qualifying period (generally a 52-week period prior to the loss of employment) is required in areas of relatively high unemployment (over 13 per cent) and 700 hours in areas of relatively low unemployment (6 per cent or lower).

EI Entrance Requirements

Regional rate of unemployment (%)	Required number of insured hours of employment in the qualification period
6 and under	700
Over 6 to 7	665
Over 7 to 8	630
Over 8 to 9	595
Over 9 to 10	560
Over 10 to 11	525
Over 11 to 12	490
Over 12 to 13	455
Over 13	420

An exception are those that are considered new entrants or re-entrants to the labour market who are required to work a minimum of 910 hours in their qualifying period, regardless of regional EI unemployment rates, in order to access EI benefits. A claimant is considered a new entrant or re-entrant if they had fewer than 490 hours of labour force attachment in the 52 week period prior to the qualifying period (pre-qualifying period). Labour force attachment takes account of various forms of attachment to the labour force, such as insured hours of work, time spent on EI, worker's compensation benefits, disability benefits and sick leave benefits in addition to actual hours of work in the labour force, with each week of labour force attachment counting for 35 hours. Claimants with at least one week of maternity or parental benefits in the four-year window preceding the pre-qualifying period are not considered new entrants or re-entrants to the labour market.

For paid employees in insurable employment, a flat entrance requirement of 600 hours of insurable employment in the 52-week period immediately preceding the claim or the period since the start of the previous claim applies for all EI special benefits. This requirement does not vary according to regional unemployment rates. Qualification for EI fishing benefits is based on earnings, as opposed to weeks or hours of work.

To be eligible to receive special benefits, self-employed Canadians must be registered with the Canada Employment Insurance Commission and have contributed to the EI program for a period of at least 12

months. In order to qualify for special benefits, they must demonstrate that they have reduced the amount of time devoted to their business by more than 40% and have earned a minimum amount of self-employment earnings in the preceding calendar year (\$6, 515 in 2013).

2.1.2 Contribution conditions

EI is financed by employer and employee premiums. Contributions to the program begin with the first CAD \$1 earned up to a maximum insurable earnings level for 2014 of CAD 48 600. The employee premium rate for 2014 is CAD 1.88 per CAD 100 of insurable earnings. Employers pay 1.4 times the employee rate (2.63 per CAD 100). The self-employed only pay the employee premium. Employees earning less than CAD 2,000 a year can receive a premium rebate. In the province of Quebec, EI premiums are lower since the province has established its own insurance plan that replaces EI maternity and parental benefits. For 2014, the employee premium rate is CAD 1.53 per CAD 100 of insurable earnings while the employers pay \$2.14 per CAD 100.

2.2 Calculation of benefit amount

2.2.1 Calculation of gross benefit

The replacement rate is 55 per cent of average weekly insurable earnings. Since April 7, 2013, average weekly earnings are calculated from the best weeks of earnings in the qualifying period (usually 52 weeks). The number of best weeks ranges between 14 and 22 depending on the monthly regional EI unemployment rate. The maximum weekly EI benefit rate is CAD 514 per week based on the maximum weekly insurable earnings of CAD 934 for 2014.

EI claimants from low-earning families with children are eligible for the EI Family Supplement, which increases the replacement rate of their earnings. In this context, low-earning is defined as net family income under CAD 25 921. Recipients can receive up to an 80 per cent replacement rate depending on their net family income and the number and age(s) of the children (see table below). Claimants with family income below CAD 20 921 receive the full supplement available to them based on the number and age(s) of their children.

Although Family Supplement recipients can receive up to an 80 per cent replacement rate overall, the maximum weekly EI benefit rate, including the Family Supplement, is subject to the maximum of CAD 514 for 2014.

Family Supplement - rate increase

(in CAD)

Family income range	Number of children			Top-up for each additional child	Age supplement for each child under 7
	1	2	3		
Below 20 921	31.30	58.70	86.10	27.45	4.15
20 921 - 21 250	31.25	58.60	86.00	27.40	4.10
21 251 - 21 500	28.50	53.60	78.80	25.60	3.85
21 501 - 21 750	26.45	49.90	73.45	24.25	3.65
21 751 - 22 000	24.45	46.25	68.20	22.85	3.45
22 001 - 22 250	22.55	42.70	63.15	21.50	3.25
22 251 - 22 500	20.70	39.30	58.15	20.15	3.05
22 501 - 22 750	18.90	35.95	53.30	18.75	2.80
22 751 - 23 000	17.15	32.70	48.60	17.40	2.60
23 001 - 23 250	15.45	29.55	44.00	16.00	2.40
23 251 - 23 500	13.80	26.50	39.55	14.65	2.20
23 501 - 23 750	12.25	23.55	35.25	13.30	2.00
23 751 - 24 000	10.70	20.70	31.05	11.90	1.80
24 001 - 24 250	9.25	17.95	26.95	10.55	1.60
24 251 - 24 500	7.85	15.30	23.05	9.15	1.40
24 501 - 24 750	6.55	12.75	19.20	7.80	1.20
24 751 - 25 000	5.25	10.25	15.55	6.45	1.00
25 001 - 25 250	4.00	7.90	12.00	5.05	0.75
25 251 - 25 500	2.85	5.65	8.55	3.70	0.55
25 501 - 25 750	1.75	3.45	5.25	2.30	0.35
25 751 - 25 921	0.70	1.40	2.10	0.95	0.15

2.2.2 Income and earnings disregards for benefit recipients and those starting a new job

The legislation that outlines the reduction of benefits due to earnings while on claim has been the subject of several pilot projects since October of 2005. Under legislation, claimants receiving regular, parental, compassionate care or critically ill children benefits can earn (allowable earnings) up to 25 per cent of their weekly benefits or CAD 50, whichever is higher without their EI benefits being reduced. Earnings above 25 per cent or CAD 50 are deducted dollar for dollar from weekly benefits. If benefits are reduced to zero for a week, that week of entitlement is kept by the claimant for use in the benefit period. Those receiving maternity or sickness benefits have their benefits reduced dollar for dollar from the first dollar earned.

On August 5, 2012, a Working While on Claim (WWC) pilot project came into force that reduces EI benefits by 50 cents for every dollar earned, up to a threshold of 90% of the weekly insurable earnings used to calculate the EI benefit amount. Earnings above this threshold are deducted dollar for dollar from EI benefits. If benefits are reduced to zero for a week, that week of entitlement is kept by the claimant for use in the benefit period. In addition, EI recipients who had earnings between August 7, 2011 and August 4, 2012, and have not benefited from the current pilot project have the option of reverting to the rules that existed under previous WWC pilot projects (see below) for the duration of their. This pilot is scheduled to end August 1 2015.

2.3 *Tax treatment of benefit and interaction with other benefits*

Recipients of EI benefits pay income taxes on benefits received, but they are not subject to SS contributions. EI Beneficiaries whose net income exceeded CAD 60 750 in 2014 have to repay the lesser of 30% of the total regular or fishing benefits received in that taxation year or 30% of the income above that threshold. This provision does not apply to those who have not received EI regular or fishing benefits in the ten years prior to the taxation year in question. First time claimants, as well as special benefits claimants, are exempt from this repayment provision.

2.4 *Benefit duration and waiting periods*

EI regular benefits are payable for a maximum period of 45 weeks, starting after an unpaid two-week waiting period. The number of weeks of benefits to which a claimant is entitled is a function of the number of hours worked in the qualifying period and the local unemployment rate. Entitlement varies from 14 to 45 weeks.

As shown in the table below, in general, a one-percentage point increase in the regional monthly unemployment rate provides an additional entitlement of two weeks of benefits. An additional 70 hours of work adds one week of entitlement for a claimant with short employment duration (less than 1 400 hours) in the qualifying period and two weeks of entitlement to claimants with long employment duration (over 1 400 hours).

Reference date for all information is **July 1st 2014**

Country chapter for OECD series *Benefits and Wages* (www.oecd.org/els/social/workincentives)

Weeks of Entitlement to Regular Benefits

Insured Hours of Work	Regional Unemployment Rate (%)											
	6% and under	Over 6% to 7%	Over 7% to 8%	Over 8% to 9%	Over 9% to 10%	Over 10% to 11%	Over 11% to 12%	Over 12% to 13%	Over 13% to 14%	Over 14% to 15%	Over 15% to 16%	Over 16%
420-454	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	26	28	30	32
455-489	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	24	26	28	30	32
490-524	0	0	0	0	0	0	23	25	27	29	31	33
525-559	0	0	0	0	0	21	23	25	27	29	31	33
560-594	0	0	0	0	20	22	24	26	28	30	32	34
595-629	0	0	0	18	20	22	24	26	28	30	32	34
630-664	0	0	17	19	21	23	25	27	29	31	33	35
665-669	0	15	17	19	21	23	25	27	29	31	33	35
700-734	14	16	18	20	22	24	26	28	30	32	34	36
735-769	14	16	18	20	22	24	26	28	30	32	34	36
770-804	15	17	19	21	23	25	27	29	31	33	35	37
805-839	15	17	19	21	23	25	27	29	31	33	35	37
840-874	16	18	20	22	24	26	28	30	32	34	36	38
875-909	16	18	20	22	24	26	28	30	32	34	36	38
910-944	17	19	21	23	25	27	29	31	33	35	37	39
945-979	17	19	21	23	25	27	29	31	33	35	37	39
980-1014	18	20	22	24	26	28	30	32	34	36	38	40
1015-1049	18	20	22	24	26	28	30	32	34	36	38	40
1050-1084	19	21	23	25	27	29	31	33	35	37	39	41
1085-1119	19	21	23	25	27	29	31	33	35	37	39	41
1120-1154	20	22	24	26	28	30	32	34	36	38	40	42
1155-1189	20	22	24	26	28	30	32	34	36	38	40	42
1190-1224	21	23	25	27	29	31	33	35	37	39	41	43
1225-1259	21	23	25	27	29	31	33	35	37	39	41	43
1260-1294	22	24	26	28	30	32	34	36	38	40	42	44
1295-1329	22	24	26	28	30	32	34	36	38	40	42	44
1330-1364	23	25	27	29	31	33	35	37	39	41	43	45
1365-1399	23	25	27	29	31	33	35	37	39	41	43	45
1400-1434	24	26	28	30	32	34	36	38	40	42	44	45
1435-1469	25	27	29	31	33	35	37	39	41	43	45	45
1470-1504	26	28	30	32	34	36	38	40	42	44	45	45
1505-1539	27	29	31	33	35	37	39	41	43	45	45	45
1540-1574	28	30	32	34	36	38	40	42	44	45	45	45
1575-1609	29	31	33	35	37	39	41	43	45	45	45	45
1610-1644	30	32	34	36	38	40	42	44	45	45	45	45
1645-1679	31	33	35	37	39	41	43	45	45	45	45	45
1680-1714	32	34	36	38	40	42	44	45	45	45	45	45
1715-1749	33	35	37	39	41	43	45	45	45	45	45	45
1750-1784	34	36	38	40	42	44	45	45	45	45	45	45
1785-1819	35	37	39	41	43	45	45	45	45	45	45	45
1820 and over	36	38	40	42	44	45	45	45	45	45	45	45

Each EI special benefit is payable for a specified maximum duration. Maternity and sickness benefits are payable for up to 15 weeks each, parental and parents of critically ill children benefits can be paid for up to 35 weeks each, while compassionate care benefits can be paid for up to 6 weeks.

Reference date for all information is **July 1st 2014**

Country chapter for OECD series *Benefits and Wages* (www.oecd.org/els/social/workincentives)

Under the EI program, self-employed fishing is separated into two distinct qualifying periods: summer and winter fishing. Fishers who are active in both seasons can establish two claims for EI fishing benefits in a single year. All fishers who qualify for the program are entitled to up to 26 weeks of benefits per benefits period.

2.5 *Treatment of particular groups*

2.5.1 *Young persons*

None

2.5.2 *Older workers*

None

2.5.3 *Others if applicable*

3. Unemployment assistance

Employment Insurance provides a number of Employment Benefits and Support Measures (EBSMs), under Part II of the EI Act, which help unemployed workers get back to work as quickly as possible. These include:

- Long-term employment benefits available only to unemployed EI clients such as Skills Development benefits, Self-employment Assistance, Targeted Wage Subsidies and Job Creation Partnerships.
- Short-term interventions such as Employment Assistance Services which includes counselling and group services that are available to all unemployed Canadians.

3.1 Conditions for receipt

3.1.1 Employment conditions

3.1.2 Contribution conditions

3.2 Calculation of benefit amount

3.2.1 Calculation of gross benefit

3.2.1.1 Irregular additional payments

3.2.1.2 Obligations of family members

3.2.2 Income and earnings disregards for benefit recipients and those starting a new job

3.3 Tax treatment of benefit and interaction with other benefits

3.4 Benefit duration and waiting periods

3.5 Treatment of particular groups

3.5.1 Young persons

3.5.2 Older workers

3.5.3 Others if applicable

4. Social assistance

Social assistance (or welfare) is administered by the provinces and territories, which set their own rules and payment rates. The Province of Ontario's system for providing social assistance is used in this report. The announcement of the new Ontario Child Benefit in the 2007 Ontario Budget led to a restructuring of social assistance rates in August 2008 (see Section 6).

The Canadian welfare system has undergone some fundamental changes over the last decade. In almost every province and territory, more stringent eligibility criteria and administrative controls have become the norm, and benefit reductions affecting part or all of the caseload have been common. There has also been a growing focus on employment and training activities for social assistance recipients in an effort to improve their skills and employment potential. Several provinces and territories offer ancillary supports, such as child care, community start-up, and transportation allowances, in combination with employment assistance, in order to facilitate social assistance recipients' participation in the labour market.

Further, with the introduction of the Federal/Provincial/Territorial National Child Benefit initiative in 1998, increased federal support for low-income families with children has enabled most provinces and territories to use these increased payments to replace part of their social assistance or child benefit payments to families with children, and reinvest the resulting savings in new or enhanced benefits and services for low-income families with children. In many cases, provinces and territories have invested additional funds beyond their social assistance and child benefit savings.

In an effort to further lessen the financial impact of the transition from social assistance to employment, several provinces and territories have extended coverage provided by drug cards and supplementary health benefits for a specified period of time after exiting social assistance. Some jurisdictions have also introduced earned income supplements. The purpose of these supplements is to increase the financial benefit associated with employment for persons with low wages. Similarly, recent reforms to asset and earnings exemption levels in some jurisdictions have allowed social assistance recipients to accumulate certain types of assets that have been linked to reduced intergenerational dependence on social assistance.

4.1 Conditions for receipt

Social assistance is a "needs-tested" benefit. If the assets of an applicant's household are within allowable limits, non-exempted income is applied to the cost of basic needs. If there is a budgetary deficit, the household qualifies for social assistance. Where there is a budgetary surplus that is insufficient to cover the cost of a special need that is approved by welfare authorities, social assistance may be granted to cover the special need only. Each jurisdiction defines assets, income and needs in its social assistance legislation.

Eligible employable persons are actively encouraged to pursue, accept, and retain any reasonable offer of employment or retraining as an initial and continuing condition of eligibility for social assistance. Thus, many jurisdictions offer employment services and training opportunities in combination with financial assistance. Should a recipient choose not to pursue employment or retraining, he/she may be subject to penalties ranging from a specified reduction in benefits over a prescribed period of time to the full cancellation of benefits.

To ensure that those who successfully leave social assistance for employment are better off working, a number of provinces and territories have introduced earned income or working income supplements.

4.2 Calculation of benefit amount

4.2.1 Calculation of gross benefit

The total payment amount consists of a basic personal allowance, a shelter allowance to assist in the payment of (total actual) housing costs and, in some jurisdictions, allowances for regularly-recurring approved special needs (e.g., diabetic food allowance). Shelter allowances are set by provincial governments to reflect actual costs within their jurisdictions. However, in New Brunswick and Quebec, social assistance benefits are paid as a “global” benefit, and clients are responsible for apportioning the allowance to shelter and other needs as they see fit. In Ontario, there are two major social assistance programs: Ontario Works, which provides income and employment assistance for people who are in temporary financial need; and the Ontario Disability Support program, designed to meet the unique needs of people with disabilities who are in financial need, or who want and are able to work and need support. This section is based on the Ontario Works program.

Monthly Ontario Works rates, in CAD*

Effective October 2013
(basic allowance + maximum shelter allowance)

Family structure	Single	Couple
No children	626 (250+376)	1054 (458+596)
One child aged 0 - 17	940 (344+596)	1106 (458+648)
Two children aged 0 - 17	992 (344+648)	1160 (458+702)

* Social Assistance was restructured beginning in August 2008 due to the phase-in (year 2) of the Ontario Child Benefit (OCB). OCB consolidated social assistance benefits for children and the OCCS into one benefit paid to all low-income families with children.

The maximum basic needs allowance rates are based on the presence of a spouse, the number of members in the household and the number of children in the household.

In Ontario, when licensed childcare is used, a deduction can be made on the reference income for the calculation of Social Assistance. In 2012, this deduction is set at \$600 per month, per child.

4.2.1.1 Irregular additional payments

Generally, Special Needs Assistance provides items, services, or allowances related to age, disability, employment, education, training, and other special circumstances. It varies widely between jurisdictions but examples include transportation allowances, employment-related allowances, child-care subsidies, drug and medical services, as well as furniture replacement, minor home repair allowances, special diet allowances, school supply allowances, and funeral services. The provision of items of special need is on a case-by-case basis in accordance with the applicable policies and guidelines.

4.2.1.2 Obligations of family members

As a condition of continuing eligibility for assistance, beneficiaries must report immediately any change in the circumstances of their household that would affect their entitlement to assistance. In addition, some jurisdictions require that long-term social assistance clients be reviewed every year, and more frequently for short-term clients.

4.2.2 *Earnings exemptions for benefit recipients and those starting a new job*

Effective September 1, 2013, the earnings exemption allows for up to \$200 per month per family member of employment earnings before social assistance benefits are reduced. Employment earnings above \$200 reduce social assistance benefits at a rate of 50 percent. This earnings disregard does not take effect until a client household has been in receipt of social assistance for three full months.

4.3 *Tax treatment of benefit and interaction with other benefits*

Social assistance benefits are not taxable, but must be declared on a tax filer's income tax return. Benefits are counted as income in calculating entitlement to federal and provincial child tax benefits and sales tax credits (see sections 6 and 10).

4.4 *Benefit duration and waiting periods*

Benefits are paid as long as there is a need, i.e., as long as household assets are within allowable limits and non-exempt income is insufficient to cover basic needs or approved special needs, and provided that all other administrative requirements are met (e.g., job search for employable clients). There are no time limits on benefit duration in Ontario.

4.5 *Treatment of particular group*

4.5.1 *Young persons*

As a general rule, anyone who has not reached the age of majority may not receive social assistance in his or her own right except in cases of family breakdown, abuse or parenthood. Young persons receiving assistance in these circumstances are required, as a condition of ongoing eligibility, to participate fully in any academic or training program that could improve their employability.

4.5.2 *Older workers*

4.5.3 *Others if applicable*

Reference date for all information is **July 1st 2014**

Country chapter for OECD series *Benefits and Wages* (www.oecd.org/els/social/workincentives)

5. Housing benefits for rented accommodation

See section 4.2.1

5.1 *Conditions for receipt*

5.2 *Calculation of benefit amount*

5.2.1 *Calculation of gross benefit*

5.2.2 *Income and earnings disregards*

5.2.3 *Costs eligible for housing benefits*

5.3 *Tax treatment of benefit and interaction with other benefits*

5.4 *Treatment of particular groups*

5.4.1 *Young persons*

5.4.2 *Older workers*

5.4.3 *Others if applicable*

6. Family benefits

Federal level

At the federal level, child-related family benefits are paid through the monthly Canada Child Tax Benefit (CCTB). In addition to the base benefit of the CCTB, which is targeted to both low- and middle-income families, the National Child Benefit² Supplement provides additional income support to low-income families with children. The NCB Supplement is one element of the broader NCB initiative, which is a partnership among federal, provincial, and territorial governments, with a First Nations component.

Total annual federal support delivered through the CCTB system reached CAD 10.4 billion in 2013-2014, including approximately CAD 3.8 billion through the NCB Supplement.

Provincial/territorial level

The NCB initiative is intended to help facilitate the transition from welfare to work by ensuring that families leaving social assistance are financially better off as a result of working. The initiative is designed so that provinces and territories have the flexibility to adjust social assistance or child benefit payments by an amount equivalent to the NCB Supplement, and re-invest these funds into new or enhanced programs benefiting low-income families with children. Provincial/territorial NCB reinvestments and investments are made in a number of areas, including: childcare, earnings supplements and child benefits, early childhood services, and supplementary health benefits. Ontario has reinvested and invested in the Ontario Child Care Supplement for Working Families as well as in early childhood and children at risk services and municipal reinvestment strategies.

As the NCB initiative has matured, the majority of provinces and territories no longer recover federal increases to the NCB Supplement. This means that the vast majority of children living in low-income families, including those on social assistance, are currently receiving some or all of the NCB Supplement. In Ontario, NCB Supplement ceased to be recovered from social assistance payments as of August 2008.

In its 2007 Budget, the Government of Ontario announced the creation of the Ontario Child Benefit (OCB) for low-income families. In July 2007, the program delivered a non-taxable, one-time payment for 2007 of up to CAD 250 per dependent child under age 18. Monthly payments began to flow in July 2008- up to CAD 600 per year per child. The 2009 Ontario budget proposed to accelerate the phase-in of the OCB by two years. The payment increased to a maximum of CAD 1 100 a year per child in 2009. The benefit reduction threshold is the adjusted family net income of CAD 20 000 with an 8 percent reduction rate.

Conditions for receipt

A person may qualify for the Ontario Child Benefit (OCB), if they:

- are the primary caregiver of a child under 18;
- are a resident of Ontario;

² The National Child Benefit (NCB) is a joint initiative of Canada's federal, provincial and territorial governments, which includes a First Nations component. The National Child Benefit aims to prevent and reduce the depth of child poverty in Canada, promote labour market attachment by ensuring that families will always be better off as a result of working, and reduce overlap and duplication by harmonizing program objectives and benefits across jurisdictions. The NCB Supplement (to the CCTB) is the federal government's contribution to the NCB initiative.

Reference date for all information is **July 1st 2014**

Country chapter for OECD series *Benefits and Wages* (www.oecd.org/els/social/workincentives)

- have filed and had assessed a previous year's income tax return, and so have their spouse or common-law partner; and
- registered their child for the federal Canada Child Tax Benefit.

The Canada Revenue Agency will automatically review eligibility the applicant's spouse/common law partner's income tax returns from the previous year are assessed and they have registered their child for the Canada Child Tax Benefit.

If eligible, the Ontario Child Benefit is included with Canada Child Tax Benefit and National Child Benefit Supplement monthly payments.

Calculation of benefit amount

From July, 2013, to June, 2014, the OCB program provided a maximum annual benefit of CAD 1 210 for each child under age 18. Beginning July 2014 the maximum payment increased to CAD 1 310 per year for each child under age 18.

Ontario Child Benefit (OCB)

	2014 (annual basis)
Maximum per child <18	CAD 1 310
Level of adjusted family net income ³ for tax purposes where benefit starts to be reduced	CAD 20 000
Reduction rate	8%

Calculation of gross benefit

See table above.

Income and earnings disregards

See table above.

First Nations

Through the NCB, the federal government works in partnership with First Nations to achieve the shared goal of improving the quality of life for Aboriginal peoples. First Nations' NCB reinvestments provide First Nations with the opportunity to develop projects that will address child poverty and ensure

³ For the purposes of determining how much will be received for the Ontario Child Benefit, adjusted family net income is defined as:

The net income amount on line 236 of the Canada Revenue Agency personal income tax form for both the applicant and spouse/common-law partner if applicable minus any federal Universal Child Care Benefit payments.

Aboriginal children receive the best possible opportunities to develop their potential as healthy, active and contributing members of their communities. First Nations' reinvestments tend to cover a wider range of program areas than those of the provinces and territories, allowing communities to decide which priority they would like to see addressed during the course of a given year. First Nations reinvestments are categorized in five key areas: child/day care; child nutrition; early child development; employment opportunities/training programs; and community enrichment.

6.1 Conditions for receipt

All low- and middle-income families with children under the age of 18 are eligible for the base benefit of the CCTB, as well as an additional amount to low-income families with children through the NCB Supplement.

6.2 Calculation of benefit amount

See Section 6.2.1 for details on specific program parameters that determine eligibility and level of benefits.

6.2.1 Calculation of gross benefit

Federal level

The combined net income reported by both spouses (that is, family net income) is used to calculate benefit entitlements. Any benefit entitlements calculated using 2014 incomes are generally actually paid over the period July 2015 to June 2016 (although they appear in the modelling for 2014 for methodological reasons).

The Canada Child Tax Benefit provides a standard base benefit of CAD 1 471 per child under 18 plus a CAD 103 supplement for the 3rd and each additional child. The base benefit is reduced by 4 per cent of family net income in excess of CAD 44 701 for families with two or more children and 2 per cent for families with one child. In addition, a National Child Benefit (NCB) Supplement is provided to low-income families with children. The maximum NCB Supplement is CAD 2 279 for one child, plus CAD 2 016 for a second child, plus CAD 1 918 for the third and each additional child. The NCB Supplement begins to be phased out based on family net income in excess of CAD 26 021. The reduction rates are 12.2 per cent for families with one child, 23.0 per cent for families with two children and 33.3 per cent for larger families.

6.2.1.1 Irregular additional payments

6.2.2 Income and earnings disregards

6.3 Tax treatment of benefit and interaction with other benefits

Canada Child Tax Benefit payments are not taxable. (For program interactions, see above.)

6.4 *Treatment of particular groups*

6.4.1 *Young persons*

6.4.2 *Older workers*

6.4.3 *Others if applicable*

On January 1, 2013, the Federal Income Support for Parents of Murdered or Missing Children (PMMC) grant became operational. This new initiative provides a taxable payment of \$350 per week to parents of children under the age of 18 who are missing or are deceased as a result of a probable Criminal Code offence, for a period of up to 35 weeks.

7. Childcare

In 2011, almost half (46%) of parents reported using some type of child care for their children aged 14 years and younger.⁴ Use of child care tends to be lowest among parents with children under 1 year and highest among parents of children between ages 2 and 4.⁵

Percent of Parents Using Child Care⁶

Age of Child	Percent of Parents Using Child Care
Under 1 year	6.8*
1 year	34
2 years	58.6
3 years	61.8
4 years	64
5 years	52.4

*Use with caution, Source: Statistics Canada, General Social Survey 2011

The type of child care arrangements among Canadian parents tends to vary across Canada. Quebec typically relies on home daycare (50%).⁷ Meanwhile, Ontario typically relies on daycare centres (36%), while the Atlantic provinces (44%), Prairie provinces (43%) and British Columbia (40%) rely on private care.⁸ While compulsory schooling begins at age six, the majority of five year old children attend kindergarten as part of the formal education system.

Type of child care arrangement among parents using child care, by region⁹

Region	Home daycare	Daycare centre	Private care
Atlantic Provinces	16*	36	44
Quebec	50	38	10*
Ontario	19	36	32
Prairie Provinces	31	23	43
British Columbia	25*	20*	40
Canada	31	33	28

*Use with caution, Source: Statistics Canada, General Social Survey 2011

**Responses of preschool and other child care arrangements are included in calculation of percentages, but are not shown in the table. Therefore, totals will not add to 100%.

⁴ Source: Maire Sinha, Child Care in Canada, Social and Aboriginal Statistics Division, Statistics Canada, Release Date October 30, 2014 at pg. 5

⁵ Maire Sinha, Child Care in Canada, Social and Aboriginal Statistics Division at pg. 5

⁶ Maire Sinha, Child Care in Canada, Social and Aboriginal Statistics Division at pg. 5

⁷ Maire Sinha, Child Care in Canada, Social and Aboriginal Statistics Division at pg. 6

⁸ Maire Sinha, Child Care in Canada, Social and Aboriginal Statistics Division at pg. 7

⁹ Maire Sinha, Child Care in Canada, Social and Aboriginal Statistics Division at pg. 7

7.1 Child Care Costs

Parent fees for regulated care vary within and across provinces and depend on the age of the child in care, the type of care arrangement (centre-based, family care, preschool) and the hours of care (full/part time). For children age 4 and under, the median cost of full-time child care differed by province ranging from \$152 a month in Quebec to \$677 per child in Ontario.¹⁰

7.2 Child care benefits

Federal Level

In July 2006, the federal government introduced the Universal Child Care Benefit, a direct payment of CAD 100 per month to all Canadian families regardless of income for each child under the age of six, to help offset the cost of whatever child care arrangement they choose. The taxable benefit is payable to the child's primary caregiver. As of 2010 single parents are allowed to choose to include UCCB payments in their own income, or in the income of the dependant for whom an Eligible Dependant Credit is claimed, thereby providing treatment comparable to single-earner two-parent families. The UCCB is not considered income for the purposes of calculating federal income-tested benefits such as the Canada Child Tax Benefit and the Goods and Services Tax Credit.

In addition, the federal personal income tax system provides a child care expenses deduction for families with children. The child care expenses deduction is calculated on the basis of earned income. Child care expenses claimed as a deduction cannot exceed two thirds (2/3) of the earnings of the spouse with the lower earned income (see section 10.1.1 for more information). The deduction reduces taxes paid to both levels of government (federal and provincial/territorial).

Childcare benefits are not dependent on the recipient using formal childcare facilities (for example state ran childcare).

Provincial Level

The province of Ontario announced the creation of the Ontario Child Benefit (OCB) in its 2007 Budget. This measure replaced the Ontario Child Care Supplement for Working Families (OCCS) as of July 2014. The OCB increased to \$1,310, for qualifying families, per child under the age of eighteen years in July 2014. The benefit is withdrawn at a rate of 8 per cent of family income that exceeds CAD 20 000.

¹⁰ Maire Sinha, Child Care in Canada, Social and Aboriginal Statistics Division at pg. 9. These costs are based on the amount of money spent by parents, but do not consider income tax credits or other financial supports that can reduce out of pocket expenses.

8. Employment-conditional benefits

In 2007 the Government of Canada introduced an earned-income supplement, the Working Income Tax Benefit (WITB), to help make work pay for low- and modest-income Canadians. A number of provinces and territories have programs which provide earned-income supplements. These include: The New Brunswick Working Income Supplement, the Quebec Work Premium, the Manitoba Child Related Income Support Program, the Saskatchewan Employment Supplement, the Alberta Family Employment Tax Credit, the British Columbia Earned Income Benefit, the Northwest Territories Territorial Workers' Supplement and the Nunavut Territorial Workers' Supplement. In addition, all Canadian provinces offer special work-related supports to social assistance clients who are joining or rejoining the labour force. These range from coverage for special work-related expenses such as clothing, transportation and, in some jurisdictions, day care, to an actual bonus for participation in work activities. In Ontario, for example, an Other Employment and Employment Assistance Activities Benefit of up to CAD 253 once in every 12-month period for actual reasonable expenses is available for a social assistance beneficiary (and a spouse or same-sex partner) who begins employment or a training program, changes employment or begins an employment assistance activity.

8.1 Conditions for receipt

8.2 Calculation of benefit amount

8.2.1 Calculation of gross benefit

The Working Income Tax Benefit (WITB) is a refundable tax credit, which provides up to CAD 998 for single individuals and CAD 1 813 for couples and families with children in 2014. The benefit is phased in at a rate of 25% on working income greater than CAD 3 000.

For single individuals without children, the maximum benefit is paid if working income is between CAD 6 992 and CAD 11 332 in 2013. For single individuals, the WITB is reduced at 15% on net income greater than CAD 11 332. No WITB is paid when net income exceeds CAD 17 985.

For families, the maximum benefit is paid if working income is between CAD 10 252 and CAD 15 649 in 2014. For families, the WITB is reduced at 15% on net income greater than CAD 15 649. No WITB is paid when family net income exceeds CAD 27 736.

8.3 Tax treatment of benefit and interaction with other benefits

Working Income Tax Benefit payments are not taxable.

8.4 Benefit duration

Reference date for all information is **July 1st 2014**

Country chapter for OECD series *Benefits and Wages* (www.oecd.org/els/social/workincentives)

8.5 *Treatment of particular group*

8.5.1 *Young persons*

8.5.2 *Older workers*

8.5.3 *Persons with Disabilities*

The WITB includes a supplement of up to CAD 499 for persons with disabilities in 2014.

9. Lone-parent benefits

The personal income tax system provides an eligible dependant amount for single, divorced, separated, or widowed taxfilers who support a dependant. Lone parents, therefore, can reduce their tax liabilities when claiming this amount for a dependent child (see section 10).

The refundable Goods and Services Tax (GST) Credit (see section 10 for details) also contains specific provisions for lone parents. In addition to an adult credit of up to CAD 272 that lone parents can claim for themselves, they can also claim this amount for the dependent child claimed as an eligible dependant. There is also a GST credit supplement of up to CAD 143 for low-income single parents (as well as single individuals).

The Canadian federal and provincial/territorial governments do not provide support to lone parents in cases where the absent parents do not pay any child support/alimonies.

In Canada, jurisdictions have flexibility regarding their treatment of support payments for social assistance benefits. Consequently, there are slight variations across jurisdictions, and for the purpose of this exercise, Ontario is used as a provincial/territorial example for social assistance.

According to Ontario legislation, income child support and alimony payments from the absent parent are fully taken into account in the calculation of the lone parent's entitlement to social assistance. In other words, social assistance benefits are reduced dollar-for-dollar with the receipt of child support/alimony payments. This has not changed since 2001.

In addition, it should be noted that Child support payments may or may not be deductible from federal income tax. As of May 1, 1997, the federal government changed the income tax rules which apply to child support agreements. Hence, there are two general rules:

- i) Child support paid under a child support agreement dated before May 1, 1997 is tax deductible, so the parent who pays child support will be able to continue to deduct those payments for income tax purposes, and the parent who receives the child support will continue to pay income tax on child support payments.
- ii) Child support paid under a child support agreement dated on or after May 1, 1997 is not deductible nor is it considered as income for tax purposes if you receive it.

While this change to the federal tax treatment of child support payments did not have any impact related to means-tested benefits such as social assistance, it did have a direct effect on the amount of federal income-tested benefits received, such as CCTB and GST credit.

9.1 Conditions for receipt

9.2 Calculation of benefit amount

9.2.1 Calculation of gross benefit

9.2.1.1 Irregular additional payments

Reference date for all information is **July 1st 2014**

Country chapter for OECD series *Benefits and Wages* (www.oecd.org/els/social/workincentives)

9.2.2 *Income and earnings disregards*

9.3 *Tax treatment of benefit and interaction with other benefits*

9.4 *Benefit duration*

9.5 *Treatment of particular group*

9.5.1 *Young persons*

9.5.2 *Older workers*

9.5.3 *Others if applicable*

10. Tax system

The federal personal income tax system considers personal income in two ways: it taxes personal income on an individual basis (i.e. individuals pay income tax on their own income); whereas it pays benefits to people based on family income (i.e. family benefits are calculated based on the income of both spouses).

10.1 Income tax

10.1.1 Tax allowances and credits

10.1.1.1 Standard allowances

10.1.1.2 Standard tax credits

- *Basic personal amount:* All taxpayers qualify for a basic personal tax credit of CAD 1 670.70 in 2014.
- *Credit for Spouse or Eligible Dependant:* A taxpayer supporting a spouse or other eligible dependant receives a maximum tax credit of CAD 1 670.70 in 2014. If eligible for the family caregiver tax amount, CAD 309 may be added for 2014. The credits are reduced by the income earned by the dependant
- *Child Tax Credit:* A tax credit that provides up to CAD 338.25 for 2014, if eligible for the family caregiver amount, CAD 309 may be added for each dependent child under the age of 18. The credit can be claimed by either parent.
- The Goods and Services Tax Credit provides a relief of CAD 272 for each adult 19 years of age or older and CAD 143 for each dependent child under the age of 19. Single tax filers without children and with an employment income higher than CAD 8838 receive an additional CAD 143 that is phased in at a rate of 2 per cent. Single tax filers with children receive an additional CAD 143 that is not subject to phase-in. The credit received for the first dependent child of a single parent is also increased from CAD 143 to CAD 272. The total amount is reduced at a rate of five percent of net family income over CAD 35 487. The amount is paid directly to families.¹¹
- *Social security contributions:* taxpayers are entitled to claim 15 per cent of their contributions to the Canada or Quebec Pension Plans (to a maximum of CAD 2 425.50 for the Canada Pension Plan and to a maximum of CAD 2 535.75 for the Quebec Pension Plan) and their Employment Insurance premiums (to a maximum of CAD 913.68).
- *Working Income Tax Benefit (WITB)* The WITB provides a non-wastable tax credit equal to 25 percent of each dollar of earned income in excess of CAD 3 000 to a maximum credit of CAD 998 for single individuals without dependents and CAD 1 813 for families (couples and single parents). The credit will be reduced by 15 per cent of net family income in excess of CAD 11 332 for single individuals and CAD 15 649 for families. This is the default national design; provinces may choose to propose jurisdiction-specific changes to this design, subject to certain principles.
- *Canada Employment Tax Credit:* A tax credit of up to CAD 169.05 for 2014 on employment income.

¹¹ The payments that relate to the 2013 tax year are payable between July 2014 and June 2015.

- *Child care expenses:* A portion of child care expenses is deductible if incurred for the purpose of earning business or employment income, studying or taking an occupational training course or carrying on research for which a grant is received. The lower-income spouse must generally claim the deduction. The amount of the deduction is limited to the least of:
 1. the expenses incurred for the care of a child;
 2. two-thirds of the taxpayer's earned income; and
 3. CAD 7 000 for each child who is under age seven, and CAD 4 000 per child between seven and sixteen years of age. The amount for a disabled child under seventeen is CAD 10 000.

10.1.2 Income tax schedule (central government income tax)

2014 Federal Income Tax Rates

Taxable Income (CAD)	Rate (%)
0 – 43 953	15
43 954 – 87,907	22
87 908 – 136,270	26
136 271 and over	29

10.1.3 State and local income taxes

All provinces and territories levy their own personal income taxes. All, with the exception of Quebec, have a tax collection agreement with the federal government, and thus use the federal definition of taxable income. They are free to determine their own tax brackets, rates and credits. Quebec collects its own personal income tax and is free to determine all of the tax parameters, including taxable income. In practice, its definition of taxable income is similar to the federal definition.

Tax regime selected for this study

The calculation of provincial tax for the average worker study assumes the worker lives in Ontario, the most populous of the 10 provinces and 3 territories. The main features of the Ontario tax system relevant to this report are summarised below:

Tax Schedule

Income Bracket	Rate (%)
CAD 0 to CAD 40 120	5.05
CAD 40 120 to CAD 80 242	9.15
CAD 80 242 to CAD 150 000	11.16
CAD 150 000 to CAD 220 000	12.16
Over CAD 220 000	13.16

Surtax

Provincial tax after accounting for wastable credits	Surtax Rate
Amounts Exceeding CAD 4 331	20% of the excess amount
Amounts Exceeding CAD 5 543	36% of the excess amount

Wastable tax credits

- A basic tax credit of CAD 488.34

- A maximum credit of CAD 414.66 for a dependant spouse or eligible dependant that is withdrawn as the income of the spouse or eligible dependant exceeds CAD 821 and is completely withdrawn when the income of the spouse is at least CAD 9 032.
- 5.05 per cent of contributions made to the Canada Pension Plan and of Employment Insurance premiums.

Non-wastable tax credits

Ontario has a Sales Tax Credit that provides a relief of up to CAD 286 for each adult and each child. It is reduced by four per cent of adjusted family net income over CAD 22 005 for single people and over CAD 27 507 for families. The amount is paid directly to families.

Tax Reduction

An earner is entitled to claim a tax reduction where the initial entitlement is equal to CAD 223 plus CAD 413 for each dependent child under the age of 19. Where someone has a spouse, only the spouse with the higher net income can claim the dependent child tax reduction. If this amount is greater or equal to the liable provincial tax, then no tax is due. If the amount is less than the liable tax, then the actual tax reduction is equal to twice the initial entitlement amount less the liable tax (if this calculation is zero or negative, the reduction is equal to zero).

10.2 Treatment of family income

Under the present system, tax is levied on individuals separately; certain tax reliefs depend on family circumstances.

10.3 Social security contributions and payroll taxes

10.3.1 Contributions payable by employees and benefit recipients

Pensions

Generally, all employees are eligible for coverage under the Canada Pension Plan (Québec Pension Plan in the province of Québec). For 2014, all employees are required to contribute to the Canada Pension Plan at a rate of 4.95 per cent of income up to a maximum contribution of CAD 2 425.50 (the contribution rate is 5.175 per cent of income for the Québec Pension Plan up to a maximum contribution of CAD 2 535.75). Income subject to contributions is earnings (wages and salaries) less a CAD 3 500 basic exemption. The maximum contribution of CAD 2 425.50 is reached at an earnings level of CAD 52 500 i.e. $(\text{CAD } 52\,500 - \text{CAD } 3\,500) \times 0.0495 = \text{CAD } 2\,425.50$. For employees, each contribution to the CPP or QPP gives rise to a tax credit equal to 15 per cent of the contributed amount. Employers are also required to contribute to the Canada Pension Plan on behalf of their employees at the same rate and can deduct their contributions from taxable income (refer § 2.21).

Self-employed persons must also contribute to the Canada Pension Plan (Québec Pension Plan in the province of Québec) on their own behalf. However, the self-employed are required to contribute at the combined employer/employee rate of 9.90 per cent of earnings up to a maximum of CAD 4 851. The self-employed can deduct the employer portion of their contribution from income, equal to 50 per cent of the total contribution or CAD 2 425.50. The remaining 50 per cent, representing the employee portion, is then claimed as a tax credit at 15 per cent.

Sickness

There is no national sickness benefit plan administered by the federal government. However, all provinces have provincially-administered health care insurance plans. Three provinces, Quebec, Ontario, and British Columbia, levy health insurance premiums on individuals separately from the personal income tax to help finance their health programmes.

In the case of Ontario, the premium is determined based on taxable income. Individuals who earn up to CAD 20 000 are exempt. The premium is phased in with a number of different rates to a maximum of CAD 900 for taxable income levels greater than CAD 200 600. The following table provides further details on the structure that is applicable in 2012.

The Ontario Health Premium		
Taxable Income	Fixed Component (CAD)	Variable Component
0 to CAD 20 000	0	
CAD 20 000 to CAD 25 000	0	6% of the taxable income in excess of CAD 20 000
CAD 25 000 to CAD 36 000	300	
CAD 36 000 to CAD 38 500	300	6% of the taxable income in excess of CAD 36 000
CAD 38 500 to CAD 48 000	450	
CAD 48 000 to CAD 48 600	450	25% of the taxable income in excess of CAD 48 000
CAD 48 600 to CAD 72 000	600	
CAD 72 000 to CAD 72 600	600	25% of the amount of taxable income in excess of CAD 72 600
CAD 72 600 to CAD 200 000	750	
CAD 200 000 to CAD 200 600	750	25% of the amount of taxable income in excess of CAD 200 000
Over CAD 200 600	900	

Unemployment

In general, all employees are eligible for employment insurance regular benefits. Eligibility to receive benefits is determined by insurable hours worked (with a minimum entry threshold of 420 hours). For 2014, employees are required to contribute at the rate of CAD 1.88 per CAD 100 of insurable earnings. Insurable earnings are earnings (wages and salaries) up to a maximum of CAD 48 600 in 2014. The maximum employee contribution in 2014 is therefore CAD 913.68 per year. Employment insurance contributions give rise to a tax credit equal to 15 per cent of the amount contributed.

10.3.2 Contributions payable by employers

Employers are required to contribute to the Canada Pension Plan on behalf of their employees an amount equal to their employees' contributions. Thus, employers also contribute at the rate of 4.95 per cent of earnings (less the CAD 3 500 earnings exemption) to a maximum of CAD 2 356.20.

Sickness

There is no national sickness benefit plan administered by the federal government. However, all provinces have provincially-administered health care insurance plans. Three provinces levy a special tax on employer payrolls to finance health services (Québec and Ontario) or health services and education (Manitoba). These payroll taxes are deductible from the employer's income subject to tax. In the case of the province of Ontario, employers pay a 1.95 per cent Employer Health Tax on the value of their payroll that exceeds CAD 400 000.

Unemployment

Employers are required to contribute to the employment insurance scheme. The general employer contribution is 1.4 times the employee contribution, that is, CAD 2.63 per CAD 100 of insurable earnings,

Reference date for all information is **July 1st 2014**

Country chapter for OECD series *Benefits and Wages* (www.oecd.org/els/social/workincentives)

for a maximum employer contribution in 2014 of CAD 1 278.18 per employee. Premiums are adjusted for employers who provide sick pay superior to payments provided under the employment insurance regime. All employment insurance contributions are deductible from the employer's income subject to tax.

Work injury

There is no national work injury benefit plan administered by the federal government. However, employers are required to contribute to a provincial workers' compensation plan which pays benefits to workers (or their families in case of death) for work-related illness or injury. The employer contribution rates, which vary by industry and province, are related to industry experience of work-related illness and injury. Premiums are deductible from the employer's income subject to tax. In the case of Ontario, employers in the C to K industry sector pay, on average, 2.91 per cent of the wages paid to each employee to a maximum of CAD 84 100.

10.3.3 Payroll taxes

10.4 Treatment of particular group

10.4.1 Young persons

10.4.2 Older workers

10.4.3 Others if applicable

Reference date for all information is **July 1st 2014**

Country chapter for OECD series *Benefits and Wages* (www.oecd.org/els/social/workincentives)

11. Part-time work

No special provisions.

11.1 *Special benefit rules for part-time work*

11.2 *Special tax and social security contribution rules for part-time work*

Reference date for all information is **July 1st 2014**

Country chapter for OECD series *Benefits and Wages* (www.oecd.org/els/social/workincentives)

12. Policy developments

12.1 Policy changes introduced between July 2nd 2013 and 1st July 2014

Ontario Child Benefit

As announced in the 2012 Budget, the province of Ontario increased the maximum annual OCB payment from \$1,100 to \$1,210 in July 2013.

Ontario Social Assistance

Effective September 1, 2013, the earnings exemption on social assistance will allow for up to \$200 per month of employment earnings before social assistance benefits are reduced. Employment earnings above \$200 will reduce social assistance benefits at a rate of 50 percent.

The Ontario government also increased social assistance rates by one per cent for adult Ontario Works recipients and people with disabilities receiving ODSP benefits. In addition, single Ontario Works adults without children received an additional top-up of \$14 per month.

Further information: http://www.fin.gov.on.ca/en/budget/ontariobudgets/2013/papers_all.pdf

Ontario Trillium Benefit (OTB)

The province of Ontario introduced the Ontario Trillium Benefit (OTB) in July 2012. The OTB combined three existing refundable tax credits (the Ontario Sales Tax Credit, Ontario Energy and Property Tax Credit and the Northern Ontario Energy Credit) and is delivered on a monthly basis. The government proposes to modify the payment structure so that, beginning in 2014, each recipient would have the choice to receive their benefit in a single payment at the end of the benefit year, rather than monthly payments.

Further information: http://www.fin.gov.on.ca/en/budget/ontariobudgets/2013/papers_all.pdf

12.2 Future policy changes announced since July 1st 2014

Universal Child Care Benefit

The Universal Child Care Benefit currently provides all families with up to \$1,200 per year for each child under the age of 6. The Government of Canada is proposing to increase and expand the UCCB starting in January 2015 to provide up to \$1,920 per year for each child under the age of 6, and up to \$720 per year for children aged 6 through 17.

Family Tax Cut

The Government of Canada is proposing a new Family Tax Cut, a federal non-refundable tax credit worth up to \$2,000 for couples with children under the age of 18. The proposed Family Tax Cut would allow a spouse to, in effect, transfer up to \$50,000 of taxable income to a spouse in a lower tax bracket, up to a maximum benefit of \$2,000. Couples would be able to claim the credit when they file their 2014 tax returns.

Child Care Expense Deduction

The Child Care Expense Deduction (CCED) allows child care expenses to be deducted from income when those expenses are incurred to earn employment or business income, pursue education or perform research.

Currently, the maximum amount that can be claimed under the CCED each year is limited to the least of:

- the total amount spent on child care expenses;
- two-thirds of the lower-income taxpayer's earned income; and
- the total of the maximum dollar limits for all children, that is \$7,000 per child under age 7, \$4,000 for each child aged 7 through 16 (and for infirm dependent children over age 16), and \$10,000 for children who are eligible for the Disability Tax Credit, regardless of their age.

The Government of Canada proposes to increase the dollar limits of the CCED by \$1,000. These changes would apply for the 2015 and subsequent taxation years

Ontario Child Benefit

As announced in the 2012 Budget, the province of Ontario increased the maximum annual OCB payment from \$1,210 to \$1,310 in July 2014. As part of Budget 2014, starting July 2015, the province proposes to tie future increases to the Ontario Child Benefit to inflation in Ontario.

Ontario Social Assistance

The following Ontario social assistance rate increases announced in the 2014 Budget came into effect: Beginning September 2014, a one per cent increase for individuals with disabilities on the Ontario Disability Support Program (ODSP). Beginning October 2014, a \$30 increase for singles without children receiving Ontario Works and a one per cent increase for families receiving Ontario Works. A one per cent increase for various other rates, including Assistance for Children with Severe Disabilities.

In addition, the current Northern Allowance provided through Ontario Works and ODSP was replaced with the new Remote Communities Allowance. Through the Remote Communities Allowance, clients will receive an additional \$50 per month for the first person and \$25 for each additional family member, over and above the amount provided through the current Northern Allowance.

Ontario Registered Pension Plan

The Ontario Retirement Pension Plan Act, 2014 was introduced. If passed, this act would commit the Ontario government to establishing the Ontario Registered Pension Plan by Jan. 1, 2017.

ANNEX

DEFINITION OF SOCIAL SECURITY CONTRIBUTIONS AND PAYROLL TAXES.

The following text has been adapted from Annex A of the OECD *Revenue Statistics*.

Social security contributions to general government

Classified here are all compulsory payments that confer an entitlement to receive a (contingent) future social benefit. Such payments are usually earmarked to finance social benefits and are often paid to institutions of general government that provide such benefits. However, such earmarking is not part of the definition of social security contributions and is not required for a tax to be classified here. However, conferment of an entitlement is required for a tax to be classified under this heading. So, levies on income or payroll that are earmarked for social security funds but do not confer an entitlement to benefit are excluded from this heading and shown under personal income taxes or taxes on payroll and workforce. Taxes on other bases, such as goods and services, which are earmarked for social security benefits are not shown here [...] because they generally confer no entitlement to social security benefits.

Contributions for the following types of social security benefits would, *inter alia*, be included: unemployment insurance benefits and supplements, accident, injury and sickness benefits, old-age, disability and survivors' pensions, family allowances, reimbursements for medical and hospital expenses or provision of hospital or medical services. Contributions may be levied on both employees and employers.

Social security contributions paid to institutions outside general government

Contributions to social insurance schemes which are not institutions of general government and to other types of insurance schemes, provident funds, pension funds, friendly societies or other saving schemes [are included here if they are compulsory or quasicompulsory (e.g., by virtue of agreement with professional and union organisations)]. Provident funds are arrangements under which the contributions of each employee and of the corresponding employer on his/her behalf are kept in a separate account earning interest and withdrawable under specific circumstances. Pension funds are separately organised schemes negotiated between employees and employers and carry provisions for different contributions and benefits, sometimes more directly tied to salary levels and length of service than under social security schemes.

Payroll taxes

This heading covers taxes paid by employers or employees either as a proportion of payroll or as a fixed amount per person, and which do not confer entitlement to social benefits. Examples of taxes classified here are the United Kingdom national insurance surcharge (introduced in 1977), the Swedish payroll tax (1969-1979), and the Austrian Contribution to the Family Burden Equalisation Fund and Community Tax.